Mental health screening has a built-in problem: pilots may fear that reporting symptoms could end their careers. The Germanwings co-pilot had previously suffered a severe depressive episode, returned to flying subject to conditions and later developed significant psychiatric symptoms. The investigation exposed gaps involving treating doctors, aeromedical authorities, confidentiality rules, airline reporting and the pilot's responsibility to declare himself unfit. A 2024 study by researchers at Sweden's Karolinska Institutet, based on an anonymous survey of 4,494 commercial pilots across Europe, found that 18 per cent scored above the threshold for possible depression and 23 per cent for possible anxiety disorder. Yet 69 per cent said they would use a pilot peer-support programme if they needed assistance, compared with just 36 per cent who would turn to their employer.

Moreover, unlike substance misuse, mental fitness cannot be established through a single test. Dr Samir Parikh, director of the mental health department at Fortis Hospitals, says, "Assessing mental fitness requires a different system—one based on repeated clinical assessment, validated screening, observation and confidential reporting rather than a single laboratory test."

BEYOND MENTAL SCREENING

Background vetting provides another layer. Thomas says it is intended to be "quite thorough". "It takes a few months before an Aerodrome Entry Pass (AEP) is issued to pilots, when all background checks by security agencies are satisfied," he says. A former director general of the Bureau of Civil Aviation Security (BCAS), speaking anonymously, seconds this. "While there is no psychological assessment in the background check," he says, "it is quite thorough and if there are red flags, say, someone has been radicalised, that should also show up in some shape or form." The system is not static, though. "Things change pretty quick and security protocols are also updated based on current threats," the former BCAS chief says.

Former Intelligence Bureau assistant director V.P. Singh argues that security assessment must, therefore, continue through a pilot's career. "Security checks should not end with recruitment or the initial background verification," he says. "There should also be periodic re-verification, including scrutiny of any unexplained financial transactions or changes in financial circumstances, wherever legally permissible, as well as relevant financial links that could indicate coercion, inducement or other security concerns."

That makes the answer less about finding a "rogue pilot test" than building a system of overlapping safeguards. Medical assessments, psychological screening, self-reporting, peer support, substance misuse monitoring, intelligence inputs and periodic re-verification—all have a role. The focus, experts say, should be on ongoing evaluation, not a clearance at recruitment that becomes a security certificate for life.

For India, the stakes are growing. The country has about 10,000 commercial pilots, with another 8,000-10,000 expected to enter the profession over the next five years.



"There is nothing in the training modules that can prepare a pilot for his co-pilot going rogue and attacking him"

CAPTAIN SAM THOMAS
President, Airline Pilots' Association of India



"Security checks should not end with recruitment or the initial background verification. There should also be periodic re-verification"

V.P. SINGH, *Former Assistant Director, Intelligence Bureau*

A SYSTEM OF SAFEGUARDS

FZ1073 shows why safeguards must extend beyond screening. Germanwings was a "lockout"; FZ1073 was an attack by one operating pilot on another. Captain Randhawa calls it "a case of total failure of the CRM". CRM, or crew resource management, is designed around human error, communication, workload and incapacitation. A malicious crew member presents a different threat: they know the aircraft, understand cockpit procedures and already have the access that aviation security is designed to restrict. India's rules are more explicit when the threat comes from a passenger, with an attempted or actual cockpit breach classified as the highest, Level 4 threat under 2026 DGCA rules. There is less that can be said publicly about the equivalent response to a hostile insider, since predictable security protocols can themselves become vulnerabilities.

The larger requirement is, therefore, coordination. Airlines, regulators, security agencies and law enforcement need mechanisms to ensure that credible security concerns and other serious red flags follow pilots across organisations and, where necessary, borders.

Kapil Kaul, CEO of aviation consultancy CAPA India, puts the broader case: "There has to be a well-structured and proactive consultation framework involving the regulator, airlines and the pilot community," he says. "You have to look at the entire lifecycle, recruitment, training, briefing, medical and psychological issues. Can you minimise the risk? Yes. Can you eliminate it? Very difficult." The challenge, then, is to build enough layers of vigilance to ensure that warnings don't go unheeded and the risk is minimised. ■

—with Sonali Acharjee